



Press kit

Silvia Prieto

A film by Martín Rejtman

Argentina, 1999, 35mm, Color, 92 minutes.

Spanish with English subtitles

Festivals 1999 Official Selection

- **Sundance Film Festival** - *World Premiere World Cinema*
- **Puerto Rico International Film Festival**
- **Berlin International Film Festival** *International Forum of Young Cinema*
- **UCLA Latin-American Film week** *Opening Night*
- **Miami Film Festival**
- **Chicago Latino Film Festival**
- **Buenos Aires International Independent Film Festival** *Closing Night*
- **Sundance Mercosur Producers Forum**, Rio de Janeiro, april 14th
- **San Francisco International Film Festival**
- **Philadelphia Festival of World Cinema**
- **Munich International Film Festival**
- **Lincoln Center Latin American Film Festival**
- **San Sebastian International Film Festival**
- **Festival des 3 Continents**, Nantes



Cast & Crew

Silvia Prieto

Gabriel

Silvia Prieto 2

Brite

Marcelo

Marta

Mario Garbuglia

Devi

ROSARIO BLÉFARI

GABRIEL FERNÁNDEZ CAPELLO

MIRTA BUSNELLI

VALERIA BERTUCCELLI

MARCELO ZANELLI

SUSANA PAMPÍN

LUIS MANCINI

GABRIEL CORREA

Writer, Director, Producer

Executive Producer

Production Manager

Director of Photography

Editor

Assistant Director

Set Design

Costume Design

MARTÍN REJTMAN

HERNÁN MUSALUPPI

PAULA ZYNGIERMAN

PAULA GRANDÍO

GUSTAVO CODELLA

DANIEL BARONE

ALEJANDRO HARTMANN

SEBASTIAN ORGAMBIDE

ALEJANDRA SEEBER

MÓNICA VAN ASPEREN



About the Film

Twenty-something ennui and the postcollegiate pursuits of love and identity are common motifs in American independent cinema. But they arrive as startlingly fresh when the setting is Buenos Aires and the cast a band of disimpassioned Argentineans, adrift in the sea of lifeless relationships and menial jobs. In this delightful deadpan comedy, author and filmmaker Martín Rejtman contemplates the ephemeral nature of identity through the interactions of a clique of twenty-something misfits -most notably, the sweetly vacant title character, Silvia Prieto-. Rejtman makes a stylistic show of his film's no budget origins, communicating with breezy, generous wit the universal essence of disaffected youth.

A post-modern, Holly Golightly, Silvia (Rosario Blefari), realizes that she has been drifting through life like it's a dress rehearsal and, on her 27th birthday, resolves to make changes. She gets a job in a coffee bar, buys a canary, and stops smoking pot. But these changes bring out a few eccentricities - she proudly keeps meticulous count of the coffees she serves, compulsively chops and cooks tons of chicken, and occasionally steals something. But the restless Silvia soon tires of her job, quits, and goes on a trip to the seaside. There, she meets a suave Armani-clad Italian who goes to great lengths to please her. However, the minute his back is turned, Silvia inexplicably walks away with his jacket, and packs up to return home. However, when "Armani" tracks her down in Buenos Aires, Silvia discovers she is not the only Silvia Prieto in the phone book and learns to her dismay that not even her name is distinctive. Silvia then starts developing a bizarre

obsession with the "other" Silvia Prieto, an obsession that has to do with unraveling the riddle of her own identity.

In *SILVIA PRIETO* the characters drift in search of their identities, moving nonchalantly from one moment to the next. Something similar occurs with objects: a jacket, a telephone answering machine, a canary, shampoo, fiancées - all these things are exchanged, given away, or cheerfully left behind, only to reappear with a dissonant twist, and if they don't...so what? They're likely to be replaced by somebody or something equally as unpredictable.

Rejtman's keen ear for dialogue, his affection for his characters, and his ability to coax clever nuance out of the ordinary, give *SILVIA PRIETO* a daft charm of its own. Delivering immediate laughs and leaving an incredible sweet aftertaste, *SILVIA PRIETO* is an original and enchanting meditation on what it means - or doesn't mean - to be yourself.

Rejtman's effervescent masterpiece is a glittering screwball-inspired comedy of shifting identities that centers around the ardent efforts of its strong eponymous heroine to suddenly lead her life in a radically new direction. Everything goes differently when she discovers there is more than one Silvia Prieto. Buoyed by its fanciful, rapid-fire dialogue and at times hilariously absurd story, *Silvia Prieto* is saturated by a Pop sensibility that belies a gently ironic fascination with bright logos, television slogans and the rich contradictions of consumer culture. Rejtman's deep appreciation of nonprofessional actors led him to prominent, popular Argentine singer-musicians in key roles, including Vicentico and Rosario Bléfari, who brings a spontaneous grace to her portrayal of Silvia Prieto as a young woman spinning at a crossroads of her own design. Guided by Bléfari's mellifluous voice in a wonderfully disjointed voiceover, *Silvia Prieto* offers an affectionate portrait of romantic folly that, at its end, reveals an unexpected bridge to Rejtman's lesser-known documentary work.

The Harvard Film Archive

Rejtman's radiant second feature, which follows a young woman through a short, precarious stretch of her life in Buenos Aires, is a comedy of oddball details and occasional, quiet epiphanies.

Silvia Prieto sells soap to passersby in busy city squares, pores over phone books to find women who share her name, and won't concede to settle down with either of the boyish men in her orbit. Rejtman's radiant second feature, which follows Silvia (played by the singer Rosario Bléfari) for a short stretch of her life in Buenos Aires, is a comedy of details—the statue that supposedly resembles Silvia and passes from owner to owner; the blazer Silvia permanently borrows from a wealthy male admirer; the chicken she buys every night—and occasional, quiet epiphanies. Silvia Prieto is one of the jewels of recent Argentine cinema, and perhaps Rejtman's most perfectly realized film to date.

Film At Lincoln Center

La fine non esiste

Considerato come uno dei principali fautori del rinnovamento del cinema argentino negli anni novanta, Martín Rejtman rappresenta un'anomalia: tanto stimato in patria e all'estero quanto poco o per niente conosciuto in Italia, dove non ha mai goduto di molta fortuna distributiva. A colmare questa inspiegabile lacuna ci pensa MUBI, che fino a novembre propone una retrospettiva del cineasta argentino, comprendente i primi tre straordinari lungometraggi (Rapado, Silvia Prieto, The Magic Gloves) e un delizioso cortometraggio (Shakti), temporalmente più recente.

Spesso accostato a Jarmusch e Kaurismäki, il cinema di Rejtman sfugge alle categorie. Le sue commedie minimaliste e malinconiche si giocano, con millimetrica precisione, sulle rime interne, le ripetizioni, il ritmo, come delle screwball comedy al rallentatore, fulminee negli scambi verbali e flemmatiche nella progressione drammaturgica. La narrazione è come una goccia d'acqua nel mare: muove da un punto piccolo e preciso per poi allargarsi progressivamente, abbracciando vie misteriose e collettive. Pur partendo da un solo personaggio principale, detentore della voce interiore che accompagna la narrazione, come se si trattasse di un diario, il cinema di Rejtman non può fare a meno degli altri, di una certa idea comunitaria, cangiante, improbabile, legata al passato - che si tratti di ex amori o (presunti) amici d'infanzia - e al contesto sociale di appartenenza.

L'agire dei personaggi è inscritto nelle condizioni materiali dentro cui si muovono (il lavoro, ricercato trovato alienato, la precarietà economica e sentimentale, il cerchio ristretto di amici e conoscenti, le abitudini a cui aggrapparsi), segno della difficoltà, per non dire impossibilità, di una reale viadi fuga dalla condizione esistenziale, ma anche della necessità (più o meno conscia) di condivisione, che si esprime attraverso la circolazione di persone, oggetti, energie, sentimenti. Forze misteriose che governano le esistenze, e che producono incontri fortuiti, coincidenze, rapporti dalle geometrie variabili.

La vita nel cinema di Rejtman è quel che di imprevedibile accade mentre si pianificano cambiamenti. Un moto da fermo che sembra tornare sempre al punto di partenza. Almeno in superficie. Il movimento designato è soprattutto interiore, impercettibile. E ha a che fare con il gioco mutevole delle identità e delle relazioni e soprattutto con il tentativo precario di restare aggrappati al flusso del quotidiano. Ogni film è la piccola, effimera tappa di un percorso. E per questo mai definitivo. La fine, così come una qualsivoglia nozione di climax, non esiste. I titoli di coda sopraggiungono delicatamente come dei punti di sospensione, lasciando i personaggi liberi di continuare fuori campo la loro dolce, fragile esistenza.

Giulio Casadei



About the Filmmaker

Martin Rejtman studied filmmaking at New York University. Before his debut feature, *Rapado* (1992), he wrote and directed two medium-length films: *Doli vuelve a casa* (1984-2004) and *Sitting on a Suitcase* (1986). Later he made *Silvia Prieto* (1999); *Los guantes mágicos* (2003); the documentary *Copacabana* (2006); *Entrenamiento Elemental para Actores* co-directed with Federico León (2008); *Dos disparos* (2014), *Shakti*, a short from 2019; *El Repartidor está en camino*, documentary, 2023, and *La Práctica*, feature length film, 2023.

During the past years there has been several retrospectives of his work (BAFICI; Pacific Film Archive, Berkeley, California; Festival de Valdivia; Harvard Film Archive; Jeonju International Film Festival, South Korea; Lincoln Center, New York, Tabakalera, San Sebastián; Cinemateca Portuguesa, MUBI, Cinemateca Uruguaya, Filmoteca Española, etc.). Besides being a filmmaker Martín Rejtman is a writer as well. He published *Rapado* (Planeta, Buenos Aires, 1992), *Treinta y cuatro historias*, *Velcro y yo* (Planeta, Buenos Aires, 1996), *Literatura y otros cuentos* (Interzona 2005/ Random House Mondadori 2018), and *Tres Cuentos* (Mondadori, 2012), *Dirty Room*, *Unsafe Location* (UDP, 2025), among other books. In 2018 he was awarded with Argentina's main cultural prize, Premio Nacional de Cultura, for the script of the film *Dos disparos*.



About the Cast

ROSARIO BLEFARI (Silvia Prieto)

Rosario Blefari is the singer and composer of the rock band "Suárez." "Suárez" has three CDs, all of which were released on F.A.N., their own independent record label: "Hora de no ver," and "Horrible." Their third album "Galope," was also released in Spain by the label Plan B. "Suárez" has toured in Spain and Chile. Rosario also plays with Maria Fernanda Aldana, from the band "El Otro Yo," -the band which appears in SILVIA PRIETO- in "Capricornio", a band which combines video, theater and music, and has played in Buenos Aires as part of an experimental music series.

As an actress, she worked in the theater with Vivi Tellas -an avant-garde stage director- in several plays. The last one, "Los Fracasados del mal," was an improvisational based on the writings of the Argentinean writer Roberto Arlt. Her latest work in the theater was "Arles 1888," where she played painter Paul Gauguin, while Valeria Bertucelli -Brite in SILVIA PRIETO- played Van Gogh. The two actresses also wrote the play. In film, she appeared in Rejtman's DOLI VUELVE A CASA, director Maria Luisa Bemberg's YO, LA PEOR DE TO DAS, and several other features and short films.

GABRIEL FERNANDEZ CAPELLO (Gabriel)

Gabriel Fernandez Capello is a singer and leader of "Los Fabulosos Cadillacs," which recently won a Grammy Award for best Latin Rock Band. The band has sold out shows in major concert venues across the United States; has countless gold and platinum albums; and has won MTV, ASCAP, and Billboard Awards, among others. The band was started while the members were teenagers living in Buenos Aires, and they developed their own unique take on music while constantly touring across the globe. Capello is married to Valeria Bertucelli.

VALERIA BERTUCELLI (Brite)

Valeria Bertucelli is a popular actress on Argentinian television series, and will star in ALMA MIA, a major Argentinian film which is currently in production. She is married to Gabriel Fernandez Capello.

MIRTA BUSNELLI (Silvia Prieto 2)

Mirtha Busnelli has acted in many Argentinian films including and has also performed in numerous television shows and theatrical productions. She appeared in Rejtman's first feature film, RAPADO.

Reviews at the time of release

"Silvia Prieto could make you think of the Nanni Moretti from the 80's, some Rohmer, such as La femme de l'aviateur, or Jarmusch's Stranger than paradise. However, Rejtman does not deserve to be compared to anyone at all, he already has his own music."

Edouard Waintrop, Libération, Paris

"A surreal symphony from Argentina (...) Set in a world of Buenos Aires slackers, Martin Rejtman's understated smartcom is a movie in which identities proliferate and disappear. The scenes are often based on trifling non-sequiturs, the low-key compositions feel studied without seeming particularly rigorous, the lighting is never less than flat. It's the sense of alternate lives that casts the shadows."

J. Hoberman, Village Voice, New York

"Excellent (...) Buenos Aires' response to master Eric Rohmer's uninhibited art. Just as in the French director's films, there is a good use of chance encounters, an intelligent dissection of mentalities and a diagnosis that is anything but indulgent. What is unusual considering he is almost a first-time director, is that there is also a clear siding with naturalism and a strong construction of characters, which is essential for the boat not to sink (...) Finally, there is a comforting opening towards metaphor in the documentary images that put an end to the performance: to examine the lives of real people and create fiction are part, according to Rejtman, of the same operation."

M Torreiro, El País, España

"A premiere that without a shadow of a doubt will mark a particular point in Argentinian cinema."

Maira Soto, Las Doce

"An unusual but very precise depiction of the characters and a hilarious script make Silvia Prieto one of the best and unique Argentine films to have been seen in a long time. This is a must."

Los Inrockuptibles

"Bresson's and Ozu's heir, as well as Jacques Tati's and the American screwball comedy from the 30's and 40's, Martín Rejtman's world is "recognizable", "typical", and even colorful, but these realistic elements appear to be slightly misplaced by an anomalous logic. More than a world, Rejtman films an economy, a machinery made out of favors, exchanges, loans, ridiculous payments and counterpayments. The tribal economy of a class without identity: the "youth". He films it both from close and faraway distances, with the knowledgeable abstinence of an inventor, and he is only faithful to one premise: neatness. Silvia Prieto is a neat film, one that trusts in the power of seeing, being seen, and seeing again. Etymologically speaking, this is a brilliant film whose brightness is not blindness but pure revelation. From that rare quality, that Argentinian films do not possess, come some others: grace, precision, elegance."

Alan Pauls, Página 30

"Writer and director Martín Rejtman, the most skillful of all independent Argentinian filmmakers, shows us in Silvia Prieto a series of characters who struggle between existentialism and the most vertiginous and urgent every day life. With the rhythm of a comedy, literary dialogues, and meaningful details, the author produces a film with a masterful performance by the multiple artist Rosario Bléfari."

Eva Grinstein, El Cronista.

"The most precise and laconically hilarious dialogues ever written in Argentinian cinema since Nini Marshall's time. One of the funniest Argentinian comedies ever."

Horacio Bernades, Página/12

"Silvia Prieto, the extraordinary film by Martín Rejtman."

Marcelo Panozzo. Clarín

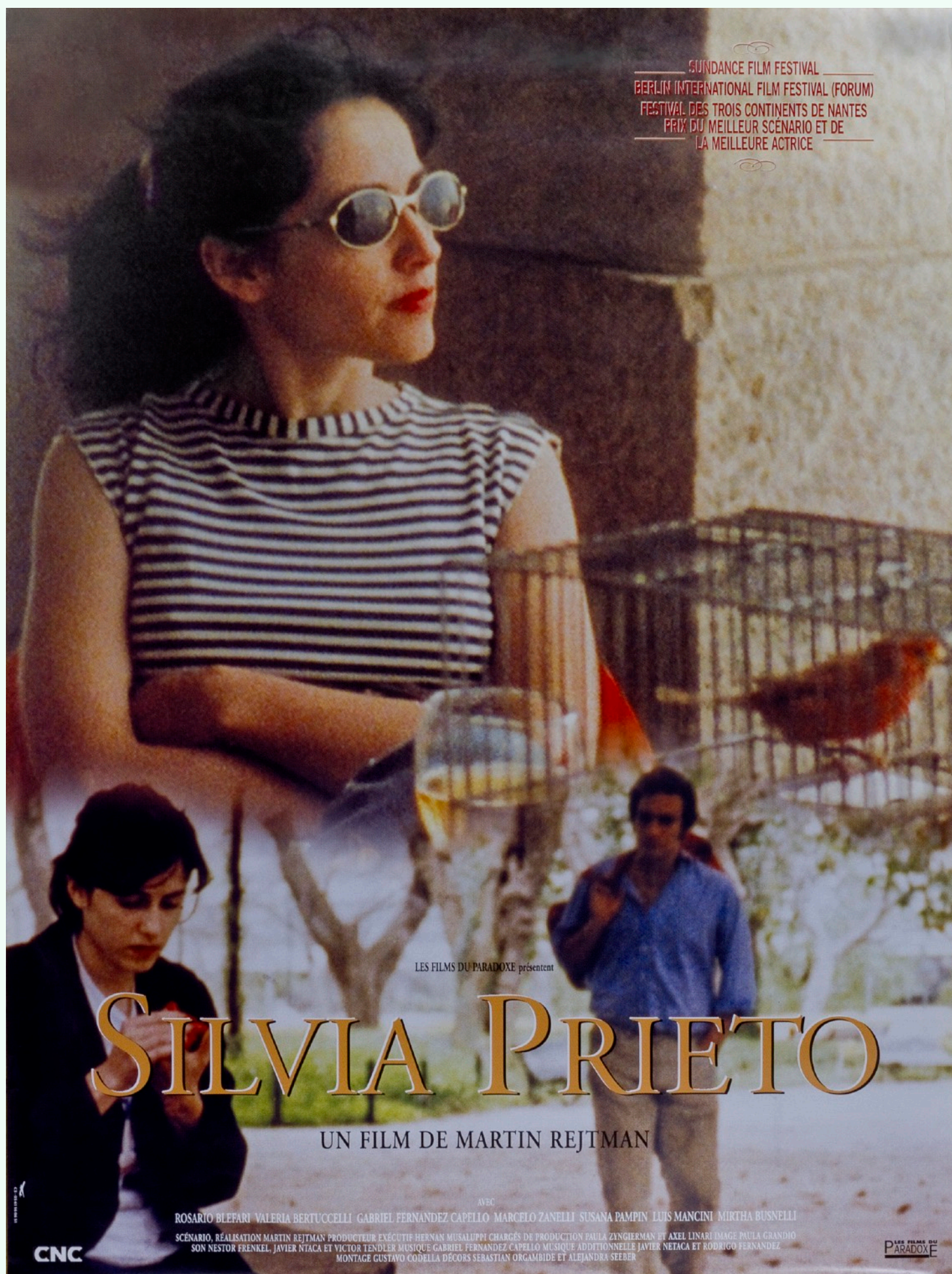
"...Rejtman has a sense of humor so bone-dry, it makes Jarmusch seem as broad as Jim Carrey (...) hugely endearing comedy, which is more like a state of mind than an ordinary movie."

The Miami Herald

"A great film. Eric Rohmer on LSD."

Diego Curubeto, Elle

Posters



una película de Martín Rejtman



SILVIA PRIETO

Con ROSARIO BLEFARI-VALERIA BERTUCELLI-GABRIEL FERNÁNDEZ CAPELLO-MARCELO ZANELLI-SUSANA PAMPIN-LUIS MANCINI- MIRTHA BUSNELLI
Fotografía y Cámara PAULA GRANDÍO Sonido NÉSTOR FRENKEL, JAVIER NTACA, VÍCTOR TENDLER Asistentes de Dirección HARTMANN, BARONE,
SOLOMONOFF Vestuario MÓNICA VAN ASPEREN Escenografía SEBASTIÁN ORGAMBIDE, ALEJANDRA SEEGER Música GABRIEL FERNÁNDEZ CAPELLO Montaje
GUSTAVO CODELLA Jefes de Producción PAULA ZYNGIERMAN, AXEL LINARI Productor Ejecutivo HERNÁN MUSALUPPI Guión, Dirección, Producción MARTÍN REJTMAN



Trailer

